WAVERLEY GATEWAY GUIDE

Connecting International Capital with Emerging & Frontier Markets

UZBEKISTAN

Eurasia

Information current as of November 2026

Dialogue | Trust | Partnership

office@lordwaverley.com
www.lordwaverley.com

WHERE AND HOW TO ENTER

KEY INVESTMENT LOCATIONS

Location / Region	Strategic Importance	Priority Sectors
Tashkent	Capital and largest commercial centre; home of the new Tashkent International Financial Centre (TIFC), operating under English common law, and host of the annual Tashkent International Investment Forum	Financial services, ICT, real estate, retail, professional services
Navoi region	Base of Navoi Mining and Metallurgical Company, one of the world's largest gold producers, and of the Navoi Free Economic Zone	Gold and precious metals, mining services, manufacturing, logistics
Almalyk / Tashkent region	Hub of Almalyk MMC, one of Central Asia's biggest base-metals producers, which commissioned a $2.7 billion processing plant at the Yoshlik-1 copper deposit in spring 2026	Copper, zinc, molybdenum, mining equipment and services
Angren and Jizzakh special industrial zones	Dedicated industrial zones offering land, property and customs incentives for manufacturing investors	Industrial manufacturing, building materials, assembly
Fergana Valley (Andijan, Namangan, Kokand, Fergana)	Densely populated eastern industrial belt with free economic zones in Andijan, Namangan and Kokand and a special low-rate tax regime in designated Fergana territories	Textiles, light industry, agro-processing, automotive components
Samarkand and Bukhara	Historic Silk Road cities anchoring Uzbekistan's tourism offer, with nearby free economic zones at Urgut, Gijduvan and Bukhoro-agro	Tourism and hospitality, agribusiness, handicrafts, food processing

INVESTOR ENTRY ROUTES

- Ministry of Investment, Industry and Trade, the lead government body for foreign investment, which organises the Tashkent International Investment Forum and supports the Foreign Investors Council (85 member companies from 19 countries)
- Law "On Investments and Investment Activities" (No. ZRU-598, in force since January 2020) guaranteeing protection against nationalisation and expropriation, protection against adverse changes in legislation, and the free transfer and repatriation of funds

- Tashkent International Financial Centre (TIFC), established by presidential decree in March 2026 and a Constitutional Law in force from July 2026, applying the common law of England and Wales with English as the official language, its own Tashkent International Commercial Court, and tax and customs preferences to 2076
- Free economic zones (10 general and 8 pharmaceutical) and the Angren and Jizzakh special industrial zones, offering land, property and water-tax exemptions, customs relief on equipment and export inputs, and profit-tax incentives of 3–10 years scaled to investment size
- Central Bank of Uzbekistan oversight of the soum and foreign-exchange market; the Investment Law guarantees the free transfer of funds into and out of the country in foreign currency
- Renewable energy and infrastructure partnerships with the state, the route used by international developers such as Masdar and ACWA Power, alongside privatisation and restructuring of state-owned banks and enterprises
- Sector incentive regimes, including IT Park benefits to 2030, reduced tax rates for textile and leather manufacturers to 2028, and a special low-rate tax regime in designated Fergana territories

MARKET-ENTRY OBSERVATION

Uzbekistan in October 2026 is one of the fastest-growing economies in the wider region and a leading destination for new investment. GDP grew 7.7% in 2025 to around $152.5 billion and accelerated to 8.5% in the first half of 2026, the highest rate in Central Asia, led by services, construction and transport, with fixed investment up 17.5%, and growth held at 8.3% in the first nine months; the EBRD raised its 2026 growth forecast to 7.5% in September. Foreign investment utilised in 2025 reached a record $43.1 billion, up 24%, of which $38.2 billion was classified as foreign direct investment under national methodology, and the June 2026 Tashkent International Investment Forum produced 166 agreements worth a further $43.1 billion with participants from 102 countries. Macroeconomic stability is improving: inflation eased to 6.4% in September 2026 from 8.0% a year earlier, international reserves stood at $66.6 billion on 1 October 2026, and public debt is around 27% of GDP. Institutional reform is gathering pace with the launch of the Tashkent International Financial Centre under English common law, the signing of an Enhanced Partnership and Cooperation Agreement with the EU in October 2025, and WTO accession now in its final stage, with 31 bilateral market-access agreements concluded.

Uzbekistan's main structural challenge is meeting fast-rising energy demand as domestic natural gas output declines. Gas production fell from 61.6 bcm in 2018 to 41.5 bcm in 2024, and the country became a net gas importer in 2023, sourcing additional supply from Russia and Turkmenistan. The government has responded with one of the most ambitious renewable programmes in the region: 42 projects totalling 4,647 MW, including solar, wind and 1,245 MW of battery storage, were commissioned in 2025, solar and wind capacity has now passed 6.3 GW, and renewables including hydropower supplied about 20% of electricity output in 2025, saving around 3.2 bcm of gas. More than 17 GW of additional renewable capacity and 6,000 km of new high-voltage lines are planned by 2030. For investors, the energy transition is therefore both a manageable operating consideration and one of Uzbekistan's largest opportunities, spanning generation, storage, grid infrastructure, energy efficiency and the industrial demand that reliable power will unlock.

INVESTOR RISK & MARKET ACCESS

KEY ENTRY BARRIERS

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
Declining domestic gas output and rising power demand	Gas production has fallen by about a third since 2018 and Uzbekistan has been a net importer since 2023, which can affect energy availability for energy-intensive projects	Rapid renewable and storage build-out (over 6.3 GW of solar and wind) is easing gas demand; energy-intensive investors can secure supply through dedicated renewable arrangements, while the 17 GW pipeline to 2030 offers major investment opportunities
Economic links with Russia	Russia accounts for 16% of trade turnover and around three-quarters of record remittances of $18.9 billion in 2025, so a Russian slowdown would be felt in Uzbekistan	Remittances from the EU, UK, US and South Korea are growing fast and trade with China, the EU and the Gulf is expanding; investors can stress-test consumer-facing plans for a softer Russian economy
Sanctions and export-control compliance on Russia-linked trade	Uzbekistan is not subject to sanctions, but Western sanctions and export controls on	Engage sanctions counsel, screen counterparties and end-users, and

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
	Russia apply to transactions, goods and counterparties connected with Russia	structure supply chains for clear compliance, which also positions investors well with Western financiers
Large state footprint in the economy	State-owned banks and enterprises remain significant, and the IMF has recommended accelerating their restructuring and privatisation; the planned NMMC listing has been paused while timing is reviewed	Privatisation and SOE reform create entry points for strategic and financial investors; use transparent tender processes and international-standard due diligence
Inflation and the cost of local credit	Inflation of 6.4% remains above the 5% target, and the policy rate has been held at 14% since March 2025	Disinflation is under way with the target set for end-2027; apply standard hedging and consider foreign-currency or DFI co-financing for larger projects
Trade deficit and gold-weighted exports	Gold made up 29.3% of exports in 2025 and the trade deficit reached $9.7 billion in January–July 2026, while about 90% of reserves are held in gold	Reserves of $66.6 billion provide a substantial buffer; export diversification under EU GSP+ and WTO accession opens opportunities in processed goods, textiles and agribusiness
Legal and institutional maturity	Investor protections and courts are still developing, although reform momentum is strong and the Foreign Investors Council has helped deliver eight regulatory acts	Use TIFC structures under English common law and the Tashkent International Commercial Court, and rely on Investment Law guarantees and investment agreements

INVESTOR RISK NOTE

Uzbekistan's risk profile is that of a fast-reforming, high-growth economy with improving buffers. The principal considerations for investors are the transition away from declining domestic gas, which is being met by one of the region's fastest renewable build-outs, and the economy's links with Russia through trade and remittances, which are being diversified as ties with China, the EU, the Gulf and other partners deepen. Uzbekistan itself is not subject to sanctions, but investors whose operations touch Russia-linked trade or counterparties should take sanctions and export-control advice as a matter of routine compliance. Institutional reform, including the TIFC's English-law framework, the EU partnership agreement and imminent WTO accession, is steadily strengthening the investment environment, and investors who enter now are well placed to benefit from privatisation, infrastructure and energy opportunities as they come to market.

MARKET ACCESS

Uzbekistan is in the final stage of accession to the World Trade Organization, with 31 bilateral market-access agreements concluded and membership targeted for 2026, which will lock in tariff and regulatory reforms. The country has been a beneficiary of the EU's GSP+ scheme since April 2021, giving duty-free access for more than 6,200 product lines, and signed an Enhanced Partnership and Cooperation Agreement with the EU in October 2025 that strengthens investment protection and trade facilitation. Foreign trade reached a record $81.2 billion in 2025, with China (21.2% of turnover), Russia (16%), Kazakhstan (6.1%) and Turkey (3.7%) the leading partners, and exports of $33.8 billion, of which gold accounted for 29.3%. Connectivity is improving rapidly: the 480 km China–Kyrgyzstan–Uzbekistan railway is in active construction and will open a direct rail route to China and strengthen Uzbekistan's role in regional transit.

WHO SHOULD THE INVESTOR MEET?

INSTITUTIONAL LANDSCAPE

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
Office of the President (Shavkat Mirziyoyev)	Drives the reform agenda, including investment liberalisation, WTO accession, the TIFC and the energy transition	Primary reference point for Uzbekistan's strategic direction and flagship projects
Ministry of Investment, Industry and Trade	Lead ministry for foreign investment, industrial policy and trade, including WTO	Standard first point of contact for market entry, investment agreements and

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
	accession and the Tashkent International Investment Forum	incentives
Central Bank of Uzbekistan	Monetary authority targeting 5% inflation by end-2027 and managing reserves of $66.6 billion	Relevant for currency, banking-sector and capital-flow matters
Tashkent International Financial Centre and Tashkent International Commercial Court	English common-law jurisdiction with its own commercial court, supporting the Tashkent International Arbitration Centre	Preferred structuring and dispute-resolution venue for cross-border transactions
Ministry of Energy	Leads the renewable build-out of more than 17 GW planned to 2030 and grid expansion	Key counterpart for power, storage and energy-efficiency investment
Navoi Mining and Metallurgical Company (NMMC)	One of the world's largest gold miners and a candidate for a future London–Tashkent listing	Relevant for mining services, supply-chain and capital-markets engagement
Foreign Investors Council	Platform of 85 international companies working with government on investment-climate reform	Direct channel for raising regulatory issues and peer intelligence

CURRENT INTERNATIONAL BUSINESS CHANNELS

The Tashkent International Investment Forum, held each June, is the country's leading dealmaking event: its fifth edition in 2026 drew more than 10,400 participants from 102 countries, hosted bilateral business forums with the US, China, South Korea, Turkey, Azerbaijan, Saudi Arabia and the UAE, and attracted global institutions including BlackRock, JPMorgan Chase, Standard Chartered, the London Stock Exchange Group, BP, Masdar and ACWA Power. The Foreign Investors Council, now 85 companies from 19 countries, offers a structured channel to government on regulatory reform. The EBRD and the IMF are closely engaged with Uzbekistan's reform programme, and international development finance institutions remain important co-financiers for energy, infrastructure and private-sector projects. The TIFC is expected to become a focal point for legal, financial and arbitration services as its regulations are adopted.

INVESTOR PROFILE BEST SUITED

Uzbekistan suits investors seeking exposure to a large and rapidly growing market at an early stage of liberalisation: renewable energy, storage and grid investors drawn by a 17 GW pipeline to 2030; mining and critical-minerals investors partnering with NMMC and Almalyk MMC; manufacturing, textile and agro-processing investors using free economic zone incentives and EU GSP+ access; financial-services, legal and fintech firms positioning around the TIFC and bank privatisation; and logistics investors building on new China rail links and regional corridors. Consumer-facing investors benefit from strong wage and remittance growth and should build standard scenarios for regional economic conditions into planning.

FROM INTELLIGENCE TO ENGAGEMENT

STEP 1: Engage the Ministry of Investment, Industry and Trade and the Foreign Investors Council
Open dialogue on sector incentives, investment agreements and Investment Law guarantees, and use the Council for practical insight into the regulatory environment.

STEP 2: Assess TIFC structuring for financial and cross-border transactions
Consider the Tashkent International Financial Centre's English common-law framework and commercial court as its regulations are adopted over the coming year.

STEP 3: Target the energy transition and critical minerals
Track renewable, storage and grid tenders and partnership opportunities with NMMC and Almalyk MMC, where the largest pipeline of new projects lies.

STEP 4: Secure free economic zone incentives for manufacturing and export entry
Engage the relevant zone administrations directly, noting that new participants from April 2026 receive profit-tax relief through accelerated depreciation.

STEP 5: Build compliance and scenario planning into the investment case
Take sanctions advice on any Russia-linked trade, hedge soum exposure, and attend the Tashkent International Investment Forum each June to build relationships.